THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

Born This Way? The Rambam Against Determinism

The Rambam's Eight Chapters, Chapter 8, Part 1

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** Chapter 8 (first part) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 7 May 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Back after Pesah

This was the first class after Pesah. The plan: finish Chapter 8 over two or three classes, then go through the Rambam's commentary on the five chapters of Pirkei Avot, which the Eight Chapters were written to introduce. The Rambam did not write on the sixth chapter.

The Rabbi reviewed the first seven chapters: the five faculties of the soul; the Torah's commands aimed at the fourth faculty (will and desire) and carried out by the senses; illnesses of the soul; the middle path, and the need to set aside time regularly to check our character, not only on Yom Kippur; directing everything to the service of God ("In all your ways know Him"); the hasid and the moshel benafsho; and the conditions for prophecy.

Why the Rambam cares so much

Chapter 8 is the longest, and its subject is free will. The Rambam treats it as a foundation for Pirkei Avot, and he returns to it in the Mishneh Torah.

The Rabbi described the attitude that bothered him: "That's the way I am. I have a hot temper." He hears it around the High Holy Days: "I did all this last year and nothing changed, so what is the point?" His answer: "the heart of it all is the recognition that we can change". If a person cannot change, as the Rambam says, the whole Torah becomes pointless, because it is all instructions on how to behave.

In the Rambam's day the threat came from astrology. Today it comes from biological determinism: the theory that if we could enter every variable of a person's life (genes, parents, community, school, culture) into a computer, we could predict every choice he will make. The Rabbi pointed out the question it cannot answer: if we are simply programmed, why should anyone be punished for a crime?

Born with a leaning, not a verdict

The Rambam opens: it is impossible for a person to be born with a virtue or a vice already in place, just as no one is born already knowing a profession. What is possible is to be born with a

propensity, a natural leaning, towards a good or a bad trait.

He illustrates with the medicine of his time (going back to Galen): a person whose brain is drier will find it easier to learn, while a person with more moisture will find abstract ideas harder. But the gifted one who never studies stays foolish, and the less gifted one who works hard can succeed. In the same way, someone of a "hot" temperament learns courage quickly, while a fearful person has to work much harder, but can get there. The power of habit and training is great.

The Rabbi gave a modern version: a high IQ that is never used is worth nothing, while a lower IQ with hours of effort achieves a great deal. He also cited the Gemara in Shabbat that someone born under Mars will shed blood. That is a propensity, not a sentence: he can become a murderer, or a shohet, or a mohel.

In terms of the earlier chapters, the question is whether faculty four, our will and desires, can change. The Rambam's answer is yes.

Two kinds of determinism

The Rabbi distinguished two forms.

- **Biological or personal.** A person is programmed by nature and upbringing.
- **Theological.** Whatever happens, at every moment, happens because God wills it at that moment. This was the view of the Mutakallimun, the Islamic theologians, and a similar idea appears in some later Hasidic writings: a leaf falls because God decided at that moment it should fall.

The Rambam rejects both. His example: Shimon kills Reuven. If Shimon was compelled to kill, why should he be punished? Rav Saadiah Gaon, in Emunot VeDeot (essay 4), goes further: on that logic the killer carried out God's will and should be rewarded, which is absurd. And every precaution would be pointless: why run from danger, if what will happen will happen?

The Rabbi applied this to the decrees of Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur. If a person is sealed for life, that refers to illness and natural events, not to another person's free choice. If someone is decreed to earn a certain sum, a thief can still choose to steal from him. And the positive side: if someone is decreed to be homeless, I can still take him into my home. Otherwise the Torah's command to look after the poor would make no sense.

The Rambam's proofs

"The truth, without any doubt, is that all a person's actions are in his own hands." That is why the Torah commands and warns, sets out reward and punishment, and says: "See, I have set before you today life and good, death and evil… choose life."

The Torah's precautions prove it too: build a fence around your roof; a man who has just become betrothed goes home from war, in case he dies there; return a poor man's pledged garment at night. None of this makes sense if everything is fixed.

The Rambam reads the verse in Eikhah, "From the mouth of the Most High do not come the evils and the good", as a plain statement: our good and bad deeds are not decreed by God. The Rabbi noted that the simple meaning is a rhetorical question, which says the opposite, so the

Rambam is reading it creatively. The verses continue: "Let us search our ways and return to Hashem." Because we chose to sin, we can choose to return.

"Everything is the will of God"

The Rambam then turns to sayings of Hazal that seem to say everything that happens to us is from God, such as the Gemara in Hullin that a person does not even injure his finger below unless it is decreed above.

His answer: when you throw a stone up and it falls, we can say it falls by God's will, meaning God made the law that heavy things fall. It does not mean God wanted, at that moment, for this stone to fall and put the idea of throwing it into your head. The same with fire rising, or a leaf you pull from a tree. Your choice is yours; what follows from it runs according to the nature God created.

"Everything is in the hands of heaven except the fear of heaven" refers to natural matters: whether a child is tall or short, whether it rains. Our moral choices are excluded.

The Rabbi quoted Rabbi Sacks, who used to answer "Where was God in the Holocaust?" with "Where was man?" Human beings have free will and can use it for terrible things; if God intervened all the time, life would lose its meaning. If lightning strikes a person who took every precaution, that is God's will; if someone else put him in danger, that person is responsible.

Miracles

Asked what a miracle is, one answer from the class was a natural event happening at exactly the right time; another was a suspension of the laws of nature. The Rambam rejects the second: the laws of nature do not change, for "there is nothing new under the sun".

Instead, every miracle was built into nature at the six days of creation. The Midrash says God made a condition with the sea when He created it that it would split for Israel; likewise that the lions would not harm Daniel, and the fire would not harm Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah. To us it looks as if nature changed. It did not. As Hazal say, the world follows its course.

A question from the class: if the sea was always going to split, was Pharaoh cornered into chasing Israel? The Rabbi said that at root this is the question of divine foreknowledge and free will, which the Rambam addresses at the end of the chapter.

Summary

- People are born with propensities, not with virtues or vices; habit and effort can change faculty four.
- The Rambam rejects both personal and theological determinism; otherwise the Torah would be pointless and unjust.
- Divine decrees concern natural events, not another person's free choices.
- "Everything is God's will" means the laws of nature, not each act.
- Miracles were built into nature at creation; nature itself does not change.

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